Since 2017, the BJP has not only given election tickets to castes like Nishads and Rajbhars but also visibly shared power with them. It is not a coincidence, for example, that it fielded four Rajbhar and five Nishad candidates (a very small proportion of its 403 candidates) in 2017, and yet, Yogi Adityanath made it a point to feature a Rajbhar (Anil Rajbhar) and a Nishad (Jai Prakash Nishad) minister in his council. This means there has been a radical shift in the profile of its leadership structures in UP at three levels: the state party organisation, ministerial portfolios, and among its district-level presidents. By 2020, OBCs accounted for over 30 per cent of the BJP's top office-bearers in the state and SCs over 16 per cent. The share of SCs (see Figure 3.4) is important because, unlike parliamentary or assembly elections, party organisational posts do not have state-mandated reservations. Representation here is even more reflective of a party's political positioning. Of the party's apex state leadership—consisting of its president and almost four dozen vice presidents, general secretaries and secretaries—thirteen were OBCs, the highest of any caste, followed by ten Brahmins and seven Thakurs. By 2020, OBCs and SCs together accounted for 46.5 per cent of the BJP's top brass in UP.

Figure 3.4: Caste Composition of UP BJP Office-bearers, 2020

